

Linux code, and built applications that can be downloaded from our website, free of cost. Media player, paint, chess games, etc, are some of the applications available for UbiSurfer. The source code is also available; the link is available on the homepage, <http://www.ubisurfer.com/>. Looking ahead, we shall continue to focus on online Web-based applications for the device. Later this year, when we shift to Google Chrome, we hope to work in close association with the community to develop applications for UbiSurfer," says Tuli. Once the firm introduces the Google Chrome OS on the newer devices, Datawind will allow those who already own UbiSurfer devices to upgrade to the Chrome OS, and they expect it should be upgradable by the customer (i.e., with no need to take it in to a service centre).

Since on-board storage is just 1 GB, one tends to wonder if the user could customise the available apps by installing new applications onto SD/SDHC cards and running from there, given that one can use up to 32 GB SDHC cards in the card slot? Tuli says that this would be possible "...for technically-oriented customers who can develop and configure Linux applications. For the average entry-level customer, this would not be necessary, as basic applications come pre-bundled."

## Support strategies

Support has been a constant constraint for Linux devices. UbiSurfer, however, has a good strategy to combat it. Datawind will provide support through its customer-support centre in Amritsar. More technical or developmental support will be escalated to the research and development engineers in Montreal, Canada. "For technical support of the Linux versions of UbiSurfer, customers would call our toll-free support line (1800 180 2 180) to diagnose the problem. If it can't be solved over the phone, and requires physical repair or replacement, then the customers would be given a Return Material Authorisation (RMA). With the RMA, they'll be able to go to the original store where they purchased it, for a swap. Over time, we plan to tie up with national repair centres too," says Tuli.

## Aggressive plans to conquer Indian markets

However, with open source netbooks still to take off in a big way in India, one would wonder how Datawind plans to make UbiSurfer a game changer in the entry-level netbook market. Well, it has put in place an aggressive marketing strategy to create interest in the right target audience. Apart from individual users, it is targeting institutional customers and enterprises with workers on the move. The firm is also working hard on penetrating into smaller cities where Internet cafés still dominate. "To create consumer awareness, we are using TV infomercials and home shopping as the primary marketing strategy. To drive sales, we have collaborated with direct sales agents, independent retailers and e-commerce platforms. Mumbai-based Sunrise Distributors is our main distributor to reach out and create the large network of independent retailers and e-commerce partners. Along with this master plan, we are in talks to zero in on regional sub-distributors to penetrate into Tier 2 and 3 cities," says Tuli.



Suneet S Tuli, CEO, Datawind

However, wooing customers was not easy for Datawind. It had to study the specifics of the disorganised Indian market with its credit-shy customers to arrive at a good strategy. "On a broader note, our marketing strategy in India is similar to other markets. However, we have introduced some modifications to reach out to potential customers. For instance, retail in India is largely disorganised, and most customers shy away from purchasing on credit. This is why we have introduced direct sales agents to reach out to them," says Tuli.

## Rolling on in the fast lane!

Looking ahead, Datawind believes that the Indian market shall continue to be attractive for the Linux-OS UbiSurfer. "In India, we see a huge demand for UbiSurfer, especially in the Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities, which are still dependent on Internet cafés and people there are eagerly looking for a personal Internet connection that is affordable. The open source version of UbiSurfer provides them that. We also see entry-level devices like UbiSurfer driving growth globally, crossing millions of units annually over the next few years. The open source OS-based netbook market globally will be driven by large players, and Google Chrome will become a dominant player in the open source OS netbook segment," says Tuli. Product enhancements are also due in the year ahead, which will add more speed to the Internet surfing front. 

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The author loves to experiment, and writing for LINUX For You is her latest experiment—so beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.